

The Top of the Food Chain

Fiction

The pigeon landed in a flurry of feathers and tucked in his wings. Bobbing his head, he strutted around looking for crumbs – this was not a difficult task as humans often passed this way and often littered the floor with the remains of their food.

He was not alone. A golden eagle was eyeing him hungrily from a post just a few metres away. As her two yellow eyes glared down on him, her talons tightened their grip on her perch. Her vicious beak opened briefly, then closed as if tasting the flavour of her next meal. The pigeon only noticed the bird of prey when she lazily stretched and flapped her wings, like she was warming up for take-off. At first, he was alarmed and fluttered upwards in a clumsy panic before settling back on the ground.

'Keep your feathers on – I've already eaten today,' she lied, as she neatly folded her enormous, brown wings.

'Me too,' he replied. 'Still, there's plenty of grub just lying around here. Shame to waste it.'

The eagle looked on with contempt as the pigeon continued to peck at the ground.

'Where do you put it all?' she sneered. 'You're so greedy!'

'No need to get personal,' said the pigeon.

'Take a look at me,' continued the eagle, ignoring his reply. 'Here at the top of the food chain, we have to take care of ourselves. We eagles are built for power and speed. Observe my sleek feathers; marvel at the span of my wings; tremble at the power of my deadly talons.' With that, she spread her wings again and gave a more forceful flap in order to prove her point.

'You are indeed a very fine specimen, madam,' agreed the pigeon, humbly. 'Nevertheless, there is more than one way to judge success. No doubt, I wouldn't last a few seconds if I had to take you on. But brute strength isn't everything. Look around you: how many eagles do you see? That's right, just the one.'

'Your point is ... ?' asked the eagle, a little impatiently.

'Well, take a peek up there on the roof. I can see three of my friends, but no eagles. Up in that oak tree, there are another four pigeons, yet none of your kind. Over there by the bench, you'll find still more of us but not an eagle in sight. What's more, this is the land of the humans – too dangerous for eagles, but we pigeons are thriving. You see, it's not about sheer, brute strength; it's about sticking together, being smart and finding new ways to get on. That's how the weaker ones can show their true worth.'

'Well, clever-claws, all your fine talk won't save you now,' snarled the eagle, spreading her wings once more and readying herself to snatch the pigeon. 'I'll make you eat your words while I prove who's the strongest.' But before she could get more than a metre into the air, she was brought back to her perch with a bump, a rattle and a clinking of metal.

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'Oh, and another thing,' continued the pigeon, not in the slightest bit flustered. 'I'm free, not tied to a post in a zoo. You might be top of the food chain, but I can see another chain. It's a man-made chain; it's attached to your leg and it's holding you back.'